

In fact, forget Windows and Linux nor now, hacking need not even involve a computer. While hacking is now predominantly associated with computers, hacking hardware is not uncommon. There are many hardware hacking enthusiasts who using some knowledge of electronics and some of software programming are able to bend their devices to their will.

While you can go all the way up to controlling your toaster over the internet, a simple example of a hardware hack anyone can do is to add a potentiometer to your headphones. A potentiometer is an electrical device which lets you control the voltage across a across it. It is a simple way of varying the voltage of a battery (or other power source) from nearly zero to all the way up to the maximum voltage the battery provides. By adding one to your headphones you can control the power of the signal going to the speakers, thereby giving them rudimentary volume control capability. Don't do this with expensive head / ear phones though as you will likely end up deteriorating the quality.

In this book we primarily deal with hacking with reference to computers and information. No single book can employ the broadest possible definition of hacking. After you are done with this book, you will have a better idea of what constitutes hacking on computers. After you are done with this book, you will probably not be able to hack in to others' computers, there are seldom good reasons for doing so, and this book is not for that. This book is meant to fuel a curious mind, and expose it to the world of hackable objects. Before we can begin though we need to address the very subject of this book, ethical hacking.

1.2 What is ethical hacking?

Hacking has been so misrepresented in the mass media that people have had to coin another term "ethical hacking" just to be clear. What does it mean really? Simply that you are a curious person, who likes to mess about with things.

You will never hear the term "ethical baker", "ethical cobbler", or "ethical librarian" but hackers have to go out of their way to ensure others that they are in fact ethical. Every time someone says they want learn how to be an ethical hacker, god kills a kitten¹. If you simply don't have the curiosity then you probably won't want the life of a hacker. And ethics, those you get from you mamma, we aren't the ones to teach you those.

Even so, with the complicated interpretation of ethics, we are left with the question, what exactly is ethical?

Put as simply as possible, being ethical is to not do things which would cause others harm. Popularly the connotation of ethical in ethical hacking is that the person performs his hacking activities within the purview of law. Which arguably might include cases where such hacking in "unethical"